



IN BRIEF

FROM CAVES TO PALACES

Prehistory is not just the story of early man. Women played a more active role than once thought—from hunting to the creation of art.

BEFORE 50,000 BCE

- **2.6 million years ago** Human ancestors first begin to use stone tools.
- **300,000 years ago** Modern humans (*Homo sapiens*) emerge as a distinct species.

50,000–15,000 BCE

- **40,800** Prehistoric peoples begin to create cave paintings in many locations, including France and Spain; up to three-quarters of the handprint stencils are made by women.
- **40,000** Neanderthals, the closest relatives to modern humans, become extinct.
- **35,000–40,000** The Venus of Hohle Fels (the oldest representation of the human figure to be excavated) is sculpted from ivory.
- **29,000** The first ovens are made for cooking meat and other food.
- **28,000–25,000** An unknown artist sculpts the small limestone figurine known as the Venus of Willendorf.
- **18,000** The earliest pottery so far discovered is made in China.

15,000–1,000 BCE

- **13,000–8,000** Humans first begin to farm crops, sparking a revolution that leads to permanent settlements and civilizations.
- **5000** In some places, humans begin to smelt copper to make tools and weapons.
- **3500–2500** Burial temples called hypogea are built in Malta, containing figurines of women.
- **2100** Cretan hieroglyphs emerge in Greece as the Bronze Age Aegean period gets underway.

◀ **THE “LADIES IN BLUE” FRESCO FEATURES THREE ELABORATELY ADORNED WOMEN FROM KNOSSOS, CRETE, C. 1525–1450 BCE.**

